RETAIL SALES ESSENTIALS

Retail Sales Essentials — Day 3: Presenting Value and Handling Objections

Study guide · Self-study

Day 3: Presenting Value and Handling Objections

How to Use This Guide

You are in your first weeks on the sales floor. You have learned how customers decide, and you have learned how to open a conversation and find out what a customer needs. Today you learn what to do with what you found out.

This guide is not reading material. It is a practice layer. Keep something to write with next to you and write as you go. When a question appears, answer it in your own words before you read on. Do that even when you feel unsure. The unsure effort is where the learning happens.

The guide builds in one direction: first you learn to present value in the customer's terms, then you learn why objections come, then you learn one method for handling them. At the end there is a quiz, a field challenge for your next shift, and model answers you should only read after you have written your own.

> **NOTES**
>
> The most common mistake at this stage is reading the whole guide in one sitting without writing. Don't do that. One section at a time, then stop and write.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know the three steps of A.R.T., MEDJAY's framework for handling objections and concerns, developed by Steven Saad, and why each step works on the customer's side of the conversation.

Attitude: You will see an objection as information about what the customer still needs to believe, not as a rejection of you or the product.

Skill: You will be able to present one product in Feature-Advantage-Benefit (FAB) form tied to a need the customer stated, and to run Acknowledge, Reframe and Transition together, in order, on a real objection.

Upskill: You will be able to stay steady and unhurried when the same objection comes back a second time, without repeating your answer louder or faster.

Why Objections Come

An objection is not a wall. It is a question the customer has not asked out loud yet.

Think about what is happening in a customer's mind at the counter. They came in with a picture of what they wanted to spend, or what they expected the product to do. You have just shown them something that does not match that picture. The gap between their picture and your product feels like risk to them. An objection is their way of saying: help me close this gap.

On Day 1 you learned that customers use fast, automatic thinking for familiar decisions and slower, effortful thinking when something feels uncertain. An objection is often the moment the slow thinking switches on. That is good news. A customer who objects is engaged. A customer who says nothing and walks away was never in the conversation.

There are only a few common sources of objection in retail:

Price. The number feels bigger than the value they can see.

Timing. They are not ready to decide today, or the purchase feels bigger than a quick one.

Need. They are not convinced this product does what they need, or that they need it at all.

Trust. They are unsure about you, the store, the return terms or the after-sale support.

Comparison. They are measuring your product against a different product, or against an imagined benchmark that does not fit.

Notice that only one of these is about money. When a customer says "it's too expensive," they usually mean "I cannot yet see why it costs that." Your job is not to lower the price. Your job is to close the gap between the price and the value.

That is where the Cost of Inaction comes in. Cost of Inaction is a plain idea, not a framework: you help the customer see what genuinely changes if they postpone the decision. Maybe the item is seasonal. Maybe their current one will need replacing anyway. Maybe they came in today because something broke. Sometimes the honest answer is that waiting costs them nothing, and it is fine to say so. Delay is not automatically bad.

> **NOTES**
>
> Listen for the difference between "too expensive" and "I can't afford it." The first is a value gap you can work with. The second is a budget fact, and pressure there damages trust.

Presenting Value: Features, Advantages, Benefits

Most new staff present features. Features are facts about the product: what it is made of, its size, its settings, its warranty length. Features matter, but they do not move a customer on their own. Customers buy what the product will do for them.

The Feature-Advantage-Benefit (FAB) structure gives you three levels:

Feature: the fact about the product.

Advantage: what the feature does, compared with the alternative.

Benefit: what that means for this customer, in their life or their work.

Only the last level is about the customer. That is why it is the one that closes the gap. And a benefit only lands if it connects to something the customer actually told you. This is why Day 2 came before today. The Question Ladder (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Rackham) gets you to the need. FAB turns that need into a presentation.

Here is the test. If your benefit sentence would sound identical to the next customer, it is not a benefit yet. It is an advantage wearing a benefit's clothes.

Practice example: A customer looking at a compact freezer says their garage is small and they mostly buy in bulk once a month. Feature: it holds 200 liters. Advantage: it fits under a standard workbench and holds a month of bulk buying. Benefit: they can buy in bulk and still park the car inside.

Why does FAB work on the customer's mind? Because it reduces effort. A customer who has to translate a feature into a personal benefit is doing work. Some will do it, most will not, especially in a busy store. When you do the translation for them, the value becomes easy to see. Easily processed information feels more familiar and more credible than information the customer has to decode.

Keep it to one product and one need at a time. Listing every feature of every model is the rookie mistake. It floods the customer with options and makes the decision harder, not easier. More choice does not restore clarity. Narrowing the field to what fits their stated need does.

> **NOTES**
>
> Write your FAB sentences before your shift. Pick three products you sell often and write one line for each level. Say them out loud. If they sound like a brochure, rewrite the benefit line until it sounds like a person.

Handling Objections with A.R.T.

A.R.T. is MEDJAY's own framework for handling objections and concerns, developed by Steven Saad. It has exactly 3 steps, used in order, and always as one chain. You do not pick one step. You run all three.

A: Acknowledge. Label the customer's feeling, with no "but" after it. "That is a lot to spend on a first purchase." "You wanted something simpler than this." "You are not sure it will last." Say it and stop. No defense, no explanation yet.

R: Reframe. Shift the decision criterion from the visible cost to the cost of inaction. Do not defend features. You are not arguing that the product is worth the money. You are changing what the customer is comparing. Instead of "this versus a cheaper model," the comparison becomes "this versus what happens if you wait or buy the wrong one."

T: Transition. Ask a calibrated how or what question. A calibrated question is one that asks the customer to think and explain, not one that asks for a yes or a no. "What would need to be true for this to feel like the right choice?" "How are you weighing the cost against how often you would use it?"

Why does each step work?

Acknowledge works because naming a feeling calms it. When you put the customer's concern into words, they do not have to hold it silently anymore. The tension drops, and they become able to listen. Acknowledging also removes the fight. The customer expected you to defend the price. You did not. That alone shifts the tone.

Reframe works because of how people compare. A price only means something next to a reference point. If the only reference in the room is a cheaper model, the price looks high. When you honestly introduce the real cost of a different decision, the same price looks different. This is not wordplay. You are showing the customer a comparison they had not considered and letting them judge it.

Transition works because it moves the conversation forward without pushing. A yes-or-no question invites a no. A how or what question invites thinking. And thinking is what a customer needs to do to decide.

One warning. A.R.T. is for objections and concerns. It is not a script for everything. Do not run it on a customer who is simply asking where the restroom is.

> **NOTES**
>
> The most common mistake is skipping the Acknowledge and jumping straight to the Reframe. It fails every time. A customer who has not been heard cannot be persuaded. Give the Acknowledge a full sentence, then pause.

Worked Example: The Second Time the Objection Comes

Here is a full chain on a real situation. Read it once, then read it again and mark where each step begins.

A customer is looking at a set of kitchen knives. The price is high for their budget. They say: "That is more than I planned to spend."

Acknowledge: "You came in with a number in mind, and this is above it."

Reframe: "The cheaper set on the shelf will cut, and it will need replacing sooner. The question is whether you want to spend once now or spend smaller amounts several times over the next few years."

Transition: "How are you thinking about the difference between the two?"

Now the customer says: "I still think it's too much." The objection came back. This is where most new staff repeat the same argument, a little louder. Do not. Run the chain again, briefly, on the new version of the concern.

Acknowledge: "It still feels like a lot, even with that in mind."

Reframe: "What you are really paying for is the years you will not have to think about it again."

Transition: "What would make this feel like a safe purchase for you?"

That last Transition is the useful one. It invites the customer to name what is actually missing. Maybe it is the return terms. Maybe it is the warranty. Now you know what to answer.

Practice example: On a practice sheet, a learner wrote out this same chain for a customer choosing between two jackets. They marked the Acknowledge line, the Reframe line and the Transition line, and read it aloud three times until it sounded like their own words.

Notice what the chain never does. It never gives a discount to end the discomfort. It never argues that the customer is wrong. It never asks "shall I wrap it up for you?" to escape the tension. That is a yes-no close, and it is the weak version. The strong version is here, in the Transition.

If the customer asks directly for a lower price, do not give it away for nothing. Ask for something of equal value in return: a faster decision, a larger bundle, a longer commitment. That is a separate rule from A.R.T., and it stands on its own.

Reflection: Think of the last time someone objected to a price you quoted, or a price you saw a colleague quote. Write down what was said. Then write what an Acknowledge line would have been. You do not need the Reframe or the Transition yet. Just the Acknowledge.

Apply It in Your Role

In a store or showroom, you rarely have a long conversation. Use what you have. If you are not on a shift yet, every line below has a version you can practice without a job.

Before a shift, or before your next practice. Pick the three products you are asked about most, or the three you have seen customers handle most. Write one FAB line for each, with the benefit tied to a common need.

At the counter, or in a role-play. When a customer states a need, echo it back in one sentence before you present. "So you need something that fits under the bench and holds a month of bulk." Then present. Then stop talking and let them react.

On the floor, or observing any store. When a customer walks toward a model, you have a few seconds. Do not launch into features. Ask one question first, then present to the answer. If you are only observing, listen for the moment the staff member skips that question.

In a busy moment. Keep the chain short. An Acknowledge can be three words. "That's a real concern." The Reframe can be one sentence. The Transition can be one question. Short is better than long.

When the customer is silent. Let the silence sit. Do not fill it with more features. The customer is thinking. Give them room.

When you are not sure. Say so, and find someone who knows. Customers trust honesty more than fluency. Admitting you need to check is not a weakness. Guessing is.

What Would You Say?

Answer these in your own words before you look at the model answers. Write first, then compare. The model answers are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

1. A customer is holding a product and says: "I like it, but it costs more than the one online." Write your Acknowledge line.

2. The same customer says: "I'm just not sure it's worth it." Write your Reframe line.

3. A customer who was ready to buy has gone quiet and is looking at the price tag. Write your Transition question.

4. A customer asks for a discount. Write the answer that keeps the chain intact and does not give anything away for free.

5. The customer repeats the same objection a third time. Write how you would respond without repeating your previous answer.

> **NOTES**
>
> Keep your answers general and pattern-level. Do not name a real customer. The point is the pattern, not the person.

Key Takeaways

- An objection is information about what the customer still needs to believe, not a rejection.
- Only one common source of objection is about money. The others are about value, timing, need, trust and comparison.
- Feature-Advantage-Benefit (FAB) turns a product fact into something the customer can see in their own life. The benefit line is the one that lands.
- A benefit only works if it connects to a need the customer stated. That is why discovery comes first.
- A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework for handling objections and concerns, has exactly 3 steps: Acknowledge, Reframe, Transition. Run all three, in order, as one chain.
- Acknowledge first, always. No "but." No defense. Give it a full sentence and a pause.
- Reframe shifts the comparison from cost to the cost of inaction. It does not defend features.
- Transition is a calibrated how or what question. Never a yes-no close.
- When the objection returns, run the chain again on the new version. Do not repeat the argument louder.
- Never give a discount for nothing. Ask for something of equal value in return.

Quiz

Choose one answer per question. Write your choice down before checking the answer key. The quiz is worth 100 points and you pass at 70. Each question is worth 20 points.

1. A customer says the price is higher than expected. What is the first step?

   A. Acknowledge the concern and label it, with no "but."
   B. Explain the product's features in more detail.
   C. Offer a small discount to keep the sale.
   D. Ask whether they want to buy it or not.

2. What is the purpose of the Reframe step?

   A. To prove the product is better than the cheaper option.
   B. To shift the comparison toward the cost of inaction.
   C. To repeat the price calmly until the customer accepts it.
   D. To move the conversation to a different product.

3. Which question fits the Transition step?

   A. "Shall we go ahead and wrap it up?"
   B. "Would you like me to check the stockroom?"
   C. "What would make this feel like the right choice for you?"
   D. "Don't you think it's worth it?"

4. A customer says: "I like it, but it costs more than the one online." Which response is the strongest Acknowledge line?

   A. "Ours is better quality, so it's worth more."

   B. "You saw a lower price elsewhere, and that matters to you."

   C. "That one is probably a different model."

   D. "We can match it if you'd like."

5. The same objection comes back a second time. What should you do?

   A. Repeat your Reframe word for word.

   B. Raise your voice slightly to sound more confident.

   C. Offer a discount to end the discomfort.

   D. Run the chain again briefly, on the new version of the concern.

Upskill Challenge

Complete this before your next shift ends, or before your next practice if you are not on a shift yet. Do the job version if you have one, and the practice version if you don't. Use the practice fields if you have no shift.

- ☐ Pick three products you are asked about most, or three you have watched customers handle. Write one Feature-Advantage-Benefit line for each, with the benefit tied to a need a customer has actually stated to you, that you have heard from a colleague, or that you have observed in a store.
- ☐ Shadow a colleague for one hour, or observe staff in any store for one hour, or record yourself role-playing a customer conversation. Write down one objection a customer raises, real or played. Mark which of the five sources it came from: price, timing, need, trust or comparison.
- ☐ Write out one full A.R.T. chain in your own words for that objection. Read it aloud until it sounds like you.
- ☐ With your supervisor's support, run one A.R.T. chain in a real conversation. If you have no shift, role-play it aloud or record it and play it back.
- ☐ Ask your supervisor for feedback on one thing you would change, or, with no shift, listen back and name one thing you would change yourself.

Write your notes here:

What I presented: ____

The objection I heard: ____

Which source it came from: ____

My Acknowledge line: ____

My Reframe line: ____

My Transition question: ____

What the customer said next (or what happened in your role-play): ____

What I would change: _____

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. The principle matters more than the exact wording.

1. "You found a lower price, and that is sitting with you." No "but," no defense. The customer feels heard, and the tension drops enough for them to keep talking. 20 points for an Acknowledge line with no "but" and no defense.

2. "The online one is cheaper today. The question is how long each one lasts and what it costs you to replace it sooner." This shifts the comparison from price to the cost of the cheaper decision over time. It does not claim the online product is bad. 20 points for a Reframe that moves the comparison without defending features.

3. "What would make this feel like a safe purchase for you?" This is a calibrated what question. It invites the customer to name what is missing, which is more useful than a yes-no close like "Shall I wrap it up?" 20 points for a how or what question, not a yes-no close.

4. "I can look at what is possible, and I would need something in return. Would a faster decision today, or a larger bundle, work better for you?" This keeps the chain intact, asks for equal value, and offers a genuine choice. 20 points for asking for equal value and never conceding for free.

5. "You are still not sure. What is the part that keeps coming back?" Run a short chain again on the new version. Do not repeat the argument louder. A repeated objection usually means the first Acknowledge did not land, or the real concern has not been named yet. 20 points for running the chain again on the new concern.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. A. Acknowledge comes first and always. A defense or a discount skips the step where the customer needs to feel heard. 20 points.
- 2. B. Reframe moves the comparison from visible cost to the cost of inaction. Defending features is the trap. 20 points.
- 3. C. A calibrated what question invites the customer to think. The other options are yes-no questions, and one of them is the weak close. 20 points.
- 4. B. Acknowledge names the customer's concern without arguing. A, C and D all skip to defense or concession. 20 points.
- 5. D. A returning objection is a new version of the concern. Run the chain again, short, on what the customer is now saying. 20 points.
- Score: _____ out of 100. Pass mark: 70.

References

Cialdini, R. B. (2021). Influence, New and Expanded: The Psychology of Persuasion. Harper Business.

Dixon, M., & Adamson, B. (2011). The Challenger Sale: Taking Control of the Customer Conversation. Portfolio/Penguin.

Kahneman, D. (2011). Thinking, Fast and Slow. Farrar, Straus and Giroux.

Kahneman, D., & Tversky, A. (1979). Prospect theory: An analysis of decision under risk. Econometrica, 47(2), 263–291.

Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007). Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli. Psychological Science, 18(5), 421–428.

Rackham, N. (1988). SPIN Selling. McGraw-Hill.

Tversky, A., & Kahneman, D. (1974). Judgment under uncertainty: Heuristics and biases. Science, 185(4157), 1124–1131.

Tversky, A., & Kahneman, D. (1981). The framing of decisions and the psychology of choice. Science, 211(4481), 453–458.

Voss, C., & Raz, T. (2016). Never Split the Difference: Negotiating As If Your Life Depended On It. Harper Business.